THE LIGHTHOUSE INSPECTOR

Written by

The Panelwise team

Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise.
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FADE IN:

1 EXT. COASTAL ROAD - DAY 1

A white bakkie bounces along a dirt road between fynbos and sand dunes. Ahead, on a headland of black rock, stands a red and white LIGHTHOUSE.

2 INT./EXT. WHITE BAKKIE - MOVING - DAY 2

MS. NAIDOO (40s), neat grey suit, clipboard on the passenger seat, drives with both hands on the wheel. A lanyard reads MARITIME SAFETY.

MS. NAIDOO
(into her phone, on speaker)
One last inspection, then I recommend it for automation. It's a formality.

SUPERVISOR (V.O.)
Be kind to the old man. He's been there thirty-two years.

3 EXT. LIGHTHOUSE - DOOR - DAY 3

A heavy green door. Ms. Naidoo knocks. Wind tugs at her jacket.

The door opens. MR. FORTUIN (70s), wool jersey with holes at the elbows, white whiskers, holds a mug of tea.

MR. FORTUIN
You're early. The kettle has only just boiled.

MS. NAIDOO
I'm here to inspect the light, Mr. Fortuin. Not to drink tea.

MR. FORTUIN
Nobody inspects anything properly without tea.

4 INT. LIGHTHOUSE - STAIRWELL - CONTINUOUS 4

An iron spiral staircase winds up and up. Ms. Naidoo climbs, counting under her breath. Mr. Fortuin climbs behind her, slowly, one hand on the rail.

MS. NAIDOO
One hundred and twelve steps. Every night?

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED:

MR. FORTUIN
Twice. Up to light it, up again at midnight to check it. My knees have opinions about it.

5 INT. LIGHTHOUSE - LAMP ROOM - DAY 5

A round glass room full of sky. In the centre sits the great LENS, rings of cut glass taller than a man, catching the daylight in rainbows.

Ms. Naidoo opens her clipboard. Mr. Fortuin polishes the lens with a soft yellow cloth.

MS. NAIDOO
A motor and a sensor could do all of this. No stairs. No knees.

MR. FORTUIN
A sensor can't see a boat in trouble.

MS. NAIDOO
There is a radio for that now.

MR. FORTUIN
(still polishing)
The radio only hears the boats that call.

She writes something down. He doesn't ask what.

6 EXT. LIGHTHOUSE - GALLERY - DUSK 6

A narrow iron balcony circles the lamp room. The sea has turned dark and rough. Clouds pile up on the horizon.

Ms. Naidoo looks out through a pair of binoculars. She stops. She looks again.

MS. NAIDOO
There. Something's out there. Past the rocks.

Mr. Fortuin takes the binoculars. Far out, a small fishing boat rolls in the swell. No lights on it.

MR. FORTUIN
Their engine's gone. They'll drift onto the reef.

7 INT. LIGHTHOUSE - LAMP ROOM - CONTINUOUS 7

Mr. Fortuin pulls a lever. Gears clank. The great lens begins to turn and the light blooms on, sweeping out across the water.

MR. FORTUIN
Get the radio. Channel sixteen. Tell the rescue station: two miles south of the light, drifting west.

Ms. Naidoo grabs the handset from the wall.

MS. NAIDOO
(into the radio)
Rescue station, rescue station, this is the lighthouse. Fishing boat adrift, two miles south, drifting west, no lights!

RESCUE OFFICER (V.O.)
Received, lighthouse. Launching now. Keep your light on them.

Mr. Fortuin cranks a small handle on the side of the lamp. The beam slows and holds on the boat.

8 EXT. SEA - NIGHT 8

The lighthouse beam pins the little fishing boat in white light. An orange RESCUE BOAT bounces over the waves toward it.

9 INT. LIGHTHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT 9

A tiny kitchen at the foot of the tower. Two mugs of tea on an oilcloth table. Ms. Naidoo's clipboard lies beside them.

She tears the top page off, folds it, and drops it in the stove. It catches and curls.

MS. NAIDOO
I'll need to come back next year. For a second inspection.

MR. FORTUIN
(pouring)
Come in the evening. The tea is better.

FADE TO BLACK.